

SALSIFY AND SCORZONERA

Tragopogon porrifolius and *Scorzonera hispanica*

Salsify and scorzonera, sometimes called black salsify, are root crops that are relatively uncommon but well worth growing if you have the space. Similar in texture to a parsnip but with an oysterlike flavor, salsify can be cooked in stews or soups, and the young leaves can be used in salads. Scorzonera is similar, but has black skin and larger leaves.

	SPRING	SUMMER	FALL	WINTER
SOW				
HARVEST				

SOWING

Both salsify and scorzonera will develop long, tapering roots, so ensure that you sow them in deep, light soil where there are no root-obstructing stones.

Both crops prefer a pH range of 6–7.5 and an open, sunny position. It is important to use fresh salsify seed every year, since old seed declines in quality and is unlikely to germinate.

Sow seed directly into the ground in mid- to late spring, as soon as the soil warms up. Sow thinly in drills at a depth of .5 in (1 cm), allowing both salsify and scorzonera 6–12 in (15–30 cm) between rows. Scorzonera can also be sown in late summer to be harvested the following fall; it is slow-growing and



Keep the leafy crops well-weeded.

can be left in the ground for up to 18 months, if necessary. Both crops can be overwintered.

CROP CARE

Keep plants well-watered and ensure that they are kept free from weeds; either apply a mulch, such as black plastic sheeting, to suppress them, or weed by hand. Using a hoe may damage the roots.